

**After Action review
of UNDP corporate response
to the crisis in Haiti
2024 - 2025**

SUMMARY REPORT

July 2026

Executive Summary

This internal After-Action Review (AAR) of UNDP's corporate response to the Haiti crisis in 2024, is a structured reflection that helps the organization identify strengths and weaknesses and learn from experience. It covers the period of the activation of corporate support as a Level 3 (L3) crisis, from March 2024 to May 2025.

To examine UNDP's response to the crisis, three primary aspects were reviewed:

- Overall clarity and timeliness of decision-making for the response
- Timeliness & effectiveness of programmatic response and the use of Corporate Funds
- Effectiveness of the operational response (Staffing capacity, SURGE, operations)

The crisis response in Haiti demonstrated the value of UNDP's corporate mechanisms for rapid action, particularly through the L3 crisis declaration, which enabled timely decision-making, strengthened coordination, and expanded technical and financial support. Collaboration between the Country Office (CO), Regional Bureau of Latin America and the Caribbean (RBLAC) and the Crisis Bureau (CB) ensured adaptive and responsive engagement including support through SURGE deployments, which was assessed as technically effective.

The transition from L3 to the protracted crisis category in May 2025 highlights the need for continued structured support arrangements to sustain operational momentum. The protracted category provides a framework for continued engagement and should be defined more specifically to ensure continued corporate attention and operational readiness.

The Rapid Crisis Impact Assessment (RCIA) continues to show strong potential as a standard tool for rapid analysis, donor outreach, and program pipeline development. As part of institutionalization, finalizing joint guidance will strengthen its positioning and usability in future crises.

In Haiti, the potential for stabilization remains contingent on improved security conditions and robust political commitments. UNDP's investments in preparedness—including remote sensing and 3D mapping—offer valuable tools for both Haiti and other conflict-affected contexts. A political agreement might be foundational for further engagement.

To sustain progress, key recommendations include prioritizing stabilization as UNDP's central programmatic entry point once conditions allow; ensuring continued corporate support under the protracted category through integrated mechanisms; strengthening procurement and HR systems for protracted crises contexts; expanding special measures; and enhancing political-level visibility, including through potential senior leadership attention.

1. Objective, scope and methodology of the AAR

1.1 Objective and scope

Guided by the Standard Operating Procedures (SOPs) on Crisis Response and Recovery, UNDP conducts After Action Reviews (AARs), following a crisis response activation, to learn from the experience and inform its approach to crisis response. The AAR documents lessons learned and offers a reflection that helps the organization to identify strengths and weaknesses, as well as sustain what was done well and identify areas for improvement. This AAR analyses UNDP's corporate response to the conflict in Haiti. It covers the **activation of the corporate response from March 2024 to May 2025**.

1.2 Methodology

To examine UNDP's response to the crisis, three dimensions have been considered to understand the programmatic and operational response to the crisis:

1. Overall Clarity and Timeliness of Decision Making for the Response
2. Timeliness and Effectiveness of Programmatic Response and the use of Corporate Funds
3. Effectiveness of the Operational Response (Staffing capacity, SURGE, Procurement and Operations)

The review of the three dimensions considers the effectiveness of UNDP's coordination and communication approaches as well as the entry points for resource mobilization.

The review is an UNDP internal process. It is based on qualitative data collection that includes a desk review of relevant UNDP internal documentation, focused on those prepared during the corporate response period and related to corporately institutionalized processes (Crisis Boards/CMSTs), as well as selected remote Key Informant Interviews (KII).

The present report is the result of the analysis conducted, reviewing relevant documentation and incorporating views of key UNDP staff involved in the response. It offers reflections on UNDP performance in the crisis response, followed by recommendations to strengthen the corporate crisis preparedness and response.

2. Lessons Learned and Recommendations

Lessons Learned

- **Effective Use of L3 Declaration:** The L3 crisis declaration enabled rapid and timely decisions aligned with UNDP's Crisis Response SOPs and strengthened corporate support on stabilization. Strong relations between RBLAC, the CO, and the Crisis Bureau facilitated adaptive and responsive support, providing the flexibility required in a crisis context.
 - The L3 declaration created **visibility** for the crisis at the senior management level, which helped strengthen visibility with partners and boost staff morale.
 - UNDP's **technical engagement** was sound, and the organization responded to relevant programmatic needs of the CO.
 - Corporate **funding allocations** for the response follow specific regulations that often require immediate expenditure. In challenging security situations, greater flexibility in the use of these funds may offer different options to the CO.
 - **Special Measures:** Implementation of special measures was highly appreciated as an important step for the organization. However, stakeholders emphasized the need to further strengthen UNDP's agility in crisis contexts by enhancing Country Office flexibility and rapid responsiveness. In this regard, existing special measures could be analyzed and potentially expanded for high-risk and protracted crises contexts.
- **L3 closure and move to protracted category:** A L3 crisis declaration offers specific funding, capacity and technical support to a CO. The closure, decided at the Crisis Board, required preparatory communication with the Regional Bureau and the CO to preempt potential uncertainty around continued support in protracted situations.
 - The protracted category provides a framework for supporting Country Offices through dedicated capacities, technical support and potential funding.
 - Haiti CO was moved to the protracted category with L3 closure. In the final Crisis Board meeting, the recommendation for continued support remained quite broad without specific recommendations.
 - UNDP delivers large portfolios in protracted crisis contexts. It is important for UNDP to be agile and ensure CO operational effectiveness in high-risk environments.
 - UNDP may further analyze needs for COs operating in fragile and protracted situations to ensure their ability for rapid action, implementation and effectiveness.
- **SURGE Deployment:**
 - SURGE deployment was assessed as effective, with technically sound support deployed to the CO.
 - The need to enforce deployment protocols was emphasized, and the rapid release of staff needs to be ensured for staff members who are part of the SURGE pool.
 - Despite challenges raised around the CO operations process, only one SURGE deployment for Operations was requested (Procurement Specialist).

- **RCIA Institutionalization and Donor Engagement:**

- The RCIA has the potential to become a standard rapid assessment tool linked to fast-track programme pipelines. Its joint approach helps prevent duplication and conflicting data, improves credibility, and can strengthen programme design. Finalizing the joint guidance note would further institutionalize roles, methodologies and approaches for future crises.
- Post-assessment engagement gap: UNDP needs stronger visibility with a clear plan for donor engagement and political outreach.
- Context matters: Political instability and donor fatigue can limit resource mobilization despite strong technical outputs.
- Speed matters: Short, focused assessments are highly valued in crisis settings; clear roles and surge capacity are critical for success.

- **Political Agreements and Stabilization:**

- Securing political agreements early with relevant players on the ground is key for stabilization programming. UNDP can integrate stabilization as a core programmatic pillar to open space for governance and recovery.
- Flexible funding and streamlined procurement processes may help rapid action. In Haiti, UNDP can further consider adopting stabilization-like approaches in adjacent areas to prevent and/or stop gang territorial control expansion.
- Anticipation mattered. Preparing stabilization plans in advance positions UNDP for quick action and donor engagement when conditions allow.

- **Innovation and Preparedness:** Tools like 3D mapping and remote sensing remain valuable for advocacy and preparedness for stabilization programming. The Haiti experience can serve as a model for other conflict-affected contexts.

- **Cross-cutting technical expertise:**

- The Haiti response demonstrated the added value of mobilizing cross-cutting technical expertise as part of corporate crisis support.
- Regular engagement and complementary expertise helped ensure timely technical advice, consistent application of corporate gender standards, stronger programme design, and more effective support to resource mobilization and institutional strengthening efforts throughout the crisis response. This experience highlights the importance of integrating such expertise early in future crisis responses.
- Strong coordination between the Country Office, Regional Gender Team and HQ Gender Team enhanced the effectiveness of gender-responsive crisis support.
- Institutional mechanisms help sustain gender-responsive crisis programming. The Gender Equality Seal, the Gender Equality Seal Crisis Track and the Haiti Gender Equality Strategy provided practical frameworks for strengthening Country Office

capacity and sustaining gender equality commitments beyond individual projects and funding proposals.

- Gender expertise should be mobilized from the onset of a crisis response and maintained throughout recovery efforts. Early and sustained engagement helps identify context-specific entry points, strengthen programme design, improve proposal quality and support more inclusive stabilization, recovery and resilience programming.

Recommendations

Country Office

- Stabilization in Haiti remains urgent and feasible if GSF Haitian National Police and Armed Forces of Haiti liberate areas from gang control. UNDP's readiness investments should be leveraged immediately when entry points emerge, with rapid activation protocols and strong political backing to demonstrate impact and attract further support.
 - Include stabilization as a key pillar in UNDP's programmatic offer.
 - Political Agreements: Secure commitments from GSF, Haitian National Police, Armed Forces of Haiti and donors for area control before deployment.
 - Stabilization-like activities or pre-stabilization initiatives: Develop activities in adjacent areas to stop gang expansion.
 - Integrated DDR: Pair stabilization with disarmament and reintegration pathways to break cycles of violence.

Regional Bureau for Latin America

- Continue and define support to the Haiti CO under the protracted category, jointly with CB, that integrates relevant corporate support and that pulls together different corporate support tools for the CO (TRAC 3, FW, SURGE, ad-hoc RM opportunities and triggering special measures).
- Continue providing dedicated technical advisory support on gender equality throughout the protracted crisis phase, including quality assurance of programme documents, strategic advice during programme design, and support to resource mobilization to strengthen gender-responsive crisis programming.

Crisis Bureau

- Continue and define support to the Haiti CO under the protracted category, jointly with RBLAC, that integrates relevant corporate support and that pulls together different corporate support tools for the CO (TRAC 3, FW, SURGE, ad-hoc RM opportunities and triggering special measures).
- Organize a UNDP internal senior management level discussion on centralization vs decentralization of operational procedures in crisis and protracted contexts. Ensure that future corporate crisis response mechanisms systematically mobilize gender expertise from the onset of a crisis and throughout preparedness, response, stabilization, recovery and resource mobilization processes.

- Define the elements of the protracted category in the SOPs, linked to the ongoing consultations on the Crisis Offer, including:
 - Corporate support for protracted crisis countries that ensure continuous engagement (flexible funding, reduction of layers, and support on domestic revenue partnerships)
 - Expanding special measures to protracted contexts.
 - Advocacy to ensure crisis and protracted countries receive higher-level corporate attention
 - Human Resources analysis across COs in protracted contexts.

BMS

- Review and adapt the special measures for (I) increased flexibility under leveled crisis declaration and (II) expanding beyond leveled crisis to include protracted crises.

BERA

- Initiate a coordinated and strategic political engagement with key international partners to align approaches on Haiti, leveraging UNDP's representation capacities in Washington D.C. and other relevant global and regional platforms. This should be undertaken in close coordination with RBLAC, ensuring alignment with regional political dynamics, UNDP's programmatic engagement, and broader UN system efforts in Haiti.